Using a password manager

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Summary

This article explains how Acme Global employees can securely store and retrieve work-related passwords using an approved password manager. It covers selection, installation, daily use, and the steps the IT Service Desk should follow when assisting users or troubleshooting issues. Following these guidelines helps meet password-policy requirements, reduces lockouts, and protects corporate data.

Symptoms

- Frequent account lockouts after 5 failed login attempts
- Users writing passwords on paper or in unsecured notes
- Repeated password-reset requests due to forgotten credentials
- Error messages such as "Your password has expired" or "Invalid username or password" when accessing corporate resources
- Difficulty remembering unique passwords for multiple SaaS applications

Common causes

- No password manager deployed or used, leading to password reuse or weak passwords
- Lack of awareness of the approved enterprise password-manager solution
- Failure to synchronize the manager with Microsoft Entra ID / on-prem AD causing authentication mismatches
- Attempts to use consumer-grade managers that are not vetted by Security Operations
- Expired or corrupted password-manager database after device changes

Overview and Benefits

Acme Global's password policy requires 14-character passwords that expire every 90?days and prohibits reuse of the last 10 passwords. Remembering dozens of unique, complex credentials is impractical, which often leads to insecure workarounds such as writing passwords down or reusing them across systems. An approved enterprise password manager solves this by encrypting credentials locally, synchronizing them across trusted devices via Intune, and providing auto-fill for web and desktop applications. Using the manager reduces lock-outs, helps meet compliance requirements, and allows the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team to issue Temporary Access Passes when needed.

Selecting an Approved Password Manager

Only password managers that have been vetted by Security Operations and integrated with Intune may be used. The current approved list includes:

- Bitwarden Enterprise (self-hosted, SAML-based SSO)
- LastPass Business (SAML SSO, admin console)
- 1Password Business (SCIM provisioning, SSO)

These solutions support Microsoft Entra ID authentication, enforce the company's password-complexity rules, and store recovery keys in Intune for Windows BitLocker/FileVault scenarios. Employees should not install any other manager without prior approval from the IAM team.

Self-Help Installation and Setup (User Procedure)

Follow these steps to install and configure the approved password manager on your Acme-managed laptop. The process is the same for Windows and macOS; mobile device steps are similar via the Company Portal app.

1. Open the **Company Portal** app (Intune) and sign in with your Acme email address.
2. Locate the approved password manager in the **Apps** list (e.g., "Bitwarden Enterprise").
3. Tap **Install** and wait for the installation to complete.
4. Launch the newly installed application.

5. When prompted, choose **Sign in with Microsoft Entra ID** (or "Work account").
6. Enter your full Acme email address (user@acme.example) and password, then approve the MFA push notification in Microsoft Authenticator.
7. Accept the permission request to allow the manager to read and store credentials.
8. Set up a local master password for the manager's vault (this is *not* your Acme domain password; it must be at least 12 characters and unique to the vault).
9. Enable the browser extension (if offered) and allow it to auto-fill login forms.
10. Perform a test: visit https://outlook.office.com, let the manager suggest saving your credentials, then log out and back in to verify auto-fill works.

If any step fails, note the error message and contact the IT Service Desk (phone?4357, Teams?"IT Help", or the self-service portal).

Daily Use and Best Practices

Once the manager is configured, incorporate it into your regular workflow to maintain security and compliance.
- Use the manager to generate new passwords when prompted by applications or when changing expired passwords (every 90?days).
- Never copy passwords to clipboard unless necessary; prefer the manager's auto-fill feature.
- Lock your vault when stepping away from the device (most managers auto-lock after a period of inactivity).
- Periodically review the **Security Dashboard** within the manager for reused or weak passwords and update them.
- If you lose access to your vault (forgot master password), do not attempt brute-force recovery; instead, contact the Service Desk for a Temporary Access Pass and vault recovery assistance.
- Keep the manager application updated via the Company Portal to receive security patches.

Service-Desk Agent Procedure

Agents should follow this procedure when a user reports problems with the password manager or needs assistance with password-related issues.

1. Verify identity: ask the user to provide their employee ID and confirm the MFA push notification in Microsoft Authenticator.
2. Determine the symptom: inability to unlock vault, sync failures, missing credentials, or master-password loss.
3. Check Intune device compliance: ensure the device is compliant and the manager app is installed and up-to-date.
4. If the user has forgotten the master password:
   a. Issue a Temporary Access Pass (TAP) via the IAM team's portal (valid for 24?hours).
   b. Instruct the user to log in to the manager with the TAP, then reset the master password and re-encrypt the vault.
   c. Confirm that the vault syncs successfully after the reset.
5. For sync or extension problems:
   a. Have the user restart the manager app and the browser.
   b. Check network connectivity and ensure the device can reach vpn.acme.example (if off-site).
   c. Re-install the manager from Company Portal if corruption is suspected.
6. Document the incident in the ticket, including the manager name, version, error codes, and steps taken.
7. If the issue persists after the above steps, escalate to the Identity & Access Management group (see Escalation section).
8. Close the ticket only after confirming the user can log in to at least two corporate applications using the manager's auto-fill.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team when:
- The user cannot regain access to the vault after a Temporary Access Pass has been issued and the master password reset fails.
- There is evidence of a compromised vault (e.g., unknown entries, unauthorized password changes).
- The password manager repeatedly fails to synchronize with Entra ID despite correct network and device compliance.

- The user requires a new master-password policy exception or integration with a legacy application not supported by the approved managers.

When escalating, include the following details in the ticket or IAM request:

- Employee name, ID, and department.
- Exact error messages and timestamps.
- Manager name and version.
- Steps already performed by the Service Desk (including any Temporary Access Pass issued).
- Device hostname, OS version, and Intune compliance status.
- Any relevant screenshots or log files exported from the manager.

The IAM team will investigate vault integrity, consider a vault recovery from Intune-backed recovery key, or coordinate a password-reset workflow as needed.

Keywords: password manager, Bitwarden, LastPass, 1Password, self-help, installation, setup, auto-fill, master password, Temporary Access Pass, TAP, MFA, Microsoft Authenticator, Entra ID, Intune, Company Portal, vault recovery, password reset, lockout, password policy, security